

am called opportunistic.

Q. Is it an alliance for Uttar Pradesh to fight Mayawati?

A. It is an alliance to fight communal forces. Mayawati along with Narendra Modi and Advani are far more lethal than George Bush.

Q. Will Sonia Gandhi and Rahul Gandhi campaign with you and Mulayam Singh in Uttar Pradesh?

A. If it happens in future, why not?

Q. Will this new alliance with Congress succeed in Uttar Pradesh?

A. It all depends on how the Congress party behaves in future with its allies and us. Congress has to be more accommodative and adjusting rather than imposing itself on others.

Q. What is the change you found in the Congress and Sonia Gandhi that you have become their ardent supporter?

A. We find her more reasonable and open to the viewpoints of others. Also we have to deal with a common enemy—Mayawati.

Q. How can you forget attacks on your friends—Amitabh Bachchan, Jaya Bachchan, Anil Ambani and Subroto Roy?

A. I have forgotten a lot and moved on and they have also. As for Bachchans, they are my family and will be. Also, I am no longer professionally associated with the Sahara Parivar.

Q. Under whose leadership will you contest the forthcoming elections?

A. Under Manmohan Singh. He is the prime ministerial candidate.

Q. I am told you are trying to bring "the brothers" together.

A. The brothers account for 5 per cent of the country's GDP. Their bickering will harm the country. Peace must prevail.

Q. How will you make sure the Government has the numbers?

A. It is an old organisation. They have got many managers and they are managing the affairs. They are leading it. And I am just assisting them.

Q. How many parties will you break to garner support?

A. I don't break parties. They will start melting when I am around. I will gather them and put them in a pot. I will not disclose the exact number but we have enough to win the vote. I will get MPs, more than I have claimed.

Q. After the Government wins confidence vote, what will be your first demand?

A. To check price rise and inflation.

Q. Will you join the Government?

A. No member of the Samajwadi Party will join the current Government under this prime minister.

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In the age of cohabitation, he is perhaps the
WILDEST PRACTITIONER OF REALPOLITIK IN
an India where ideology is negotiable.

Ratna, he is our missile man and he is a Muslim. If he says the deal is good for the country, we have to accept it," says Singh. Realising that the explanation, though reasonably "Muslim", is not ideological enough, he goes a step further. While parting ways with UNPA, of which he was an architect, and the Left on the deal, he challenged the communists to choose between the outgoing George Bush and the incoming Advani—or between the fading imperialist and the inevitable communalist. And by the way, the imperialist now just loves the man. On the fourth of July, when he walked into the American ambassador's party, he was treated as a very special guest. The ambassador took him to another room and thanked him profusely.

This star status didn't come easily to the 52-year-old man who has come a long way from the back alleys of Burrabazar in Kolkata, where he began his political career as a district-level Congress functionary. And remember, the Family approached him only as a last choice. First they used the more socially acceptable Salim Sherwani, an SP MP from Badayun, to reach out to Mulayam but failed, and the MP on his part blamed Singh as a stumbling block. An incensed Singh offered to resign but in a hastily-convened executive committee meeting of the party the top leadership voiced full confidence in him. Then the Congress tried to use Akhilesh Yadav to influence his father Mulayam. That too didn't work. It took some time for Sonia and Rahul to realise the power of Amar Singh. And the fear of Maya, whose power is absolute and who refuses to play second fiddle to

LAST NAIL: The alliance between the Congress and the SP means the Third Front in its new avatar is a non-starter